

EARLY SOCIAL STRUCTURE AND STRAIN THEORIES OF CRIME

August Comte

Coined the term “Sociology”

Developed the concepts:

Social Statics: Study of *social order and stability* (e.g., structures, institutions, hierarchies).

Social Dynamics: Study of *social change and progress* (e.g., evolution and development of social institutions).

Example: Civil Rights Movement



Adolphe Quetelet (KAH-tay-lay)

Belgian mathematician and sociologist;
introduced statistical methods to the
social sciences.

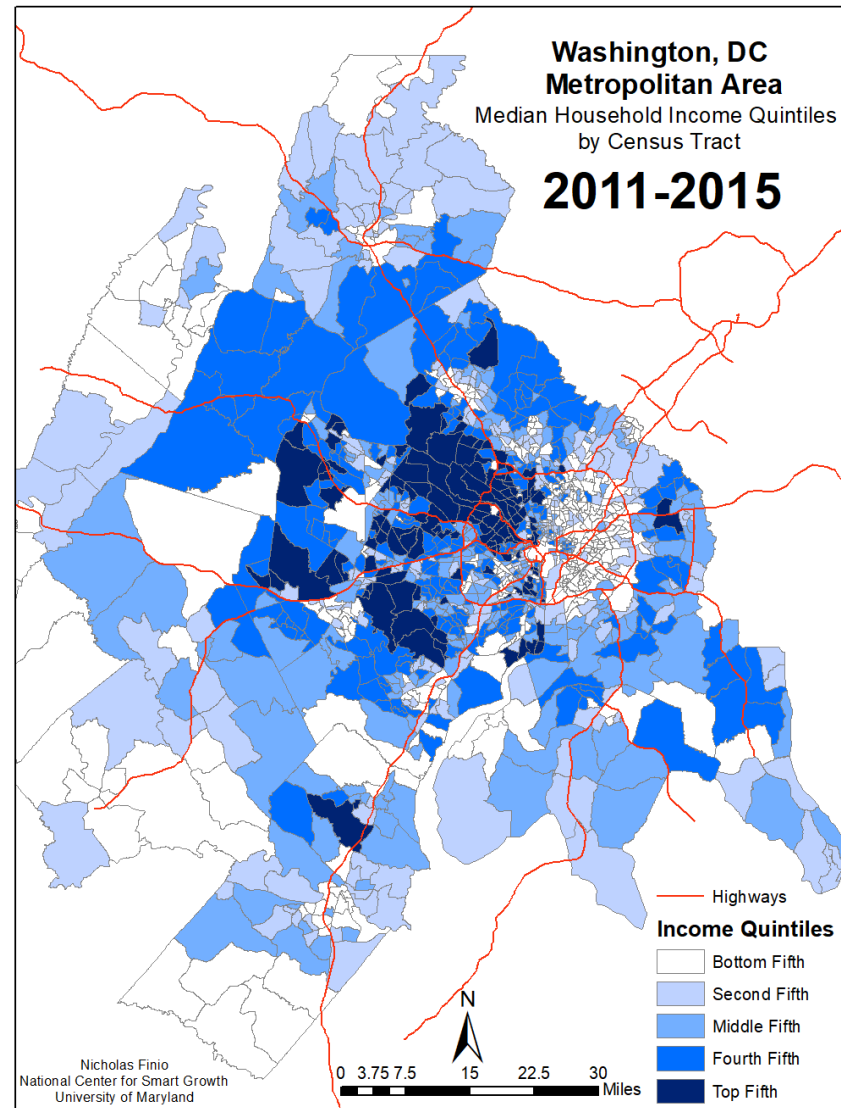
Relative Deprivation

The perception of inequality or
unfairness when individuals/groups
compare their status to others in close
proximity, fueling frustration and
deviant behavior.

Example: Washington DC and High
crime rates, neighborhoods are
adjacent to affluent areas reflect
inequality and contribute to
deprivation.



Relative Deprivation

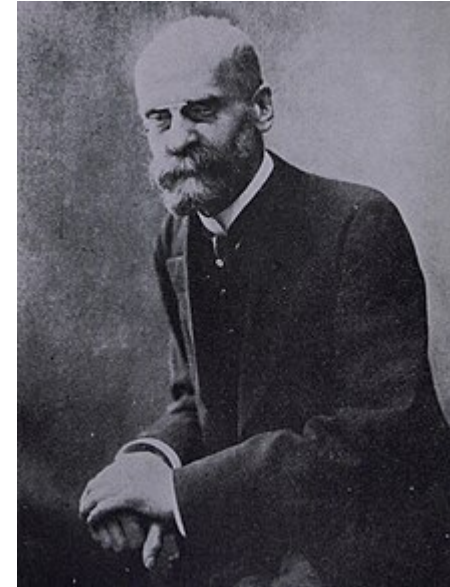


Émile Durkheim

French sociologist (1858–1917),
often called one of the **founders
of modern sociology**

Emphasized empirical research
and the importance of objective
data (e.g., statistics) in studying
social phenomena

His concepts (e.g., anomie)
remain central to sociological
theory, informing research on
social integration, norms, and
collective behavior



Émile Durkheim and Anomie

Anomie

A state of social instability (“normlessness”) where societal norms, values, and regulations break down, leading to: confusion about acceptable behavior, alienation from community, increased deviance/crime

Key Causes/Triggers:

1.) Rapid Social Change

Industrialization, urbanization, or technological disruption

2.) Economic Crises

Sudden wealth inequality or unemployment (e.g., Great Depression)

3.) Cultural Shifts

Collapse of traditional values without new norms to replace them

Émile Durkheim and Anomie

Collective Conscious the degree in which individuals of society are **think alike or have similar norms and values**. Leads to social cohesion.

Industrialization led Mechanical Societies into Organic Societies

Mechanical Societies

Organic Societies

Primitive

Modern

Rural

Urban

Agricultural based

Industrial based

Simple division of labor

Complex division of labor
(specialization focused)

Law used to enforce conformity

Law used to regulate division
interactions

Stronger collective conscious

Weaker collective consciousness

Émile Durkheim and Anomie

1 Rapid Social Change (e.g., industrialization, economic booms/busts, technological disruption) →

2 Breakdown of Norms (e.g., old rules lose relevance; new norms are absent/weak) →

3 Anomie (i.e., “normlessness” – society fails to regulate goals/behavior) →

🚩 Social Consequences = ↓ Collective Conscious

Émile Durkheim and Suicide

In *Suicide* (1897), Durkheim examined how social integration and regulation affect suicide rates

He examined popular religious groups in that time, and found that Catholics, with *stronger social bonds*, had lower suicide rates than Protestants, *who experienced weaker collective ties*

Showed that when social norms weaken (i.e., anomie occurs) the risk of suicide increases. Thus, social factors influence individual behavior

Keep in mind that in 1897, societal attitudes toward suicide were still largely dogmatic, often regarding it both as a grave moral failing and a criminal act



Émile Durkheim and Suicide

Why this matters:

- 1 Societal conditions can drive individual behaviors like suicide or other forms of deviance
- 2 Which emphasizes that personal acts or crimes often stem from broader social forces such as weakened communal bonds or unclear expectations
- 3 Durkheim's work shifts focus away from purely individual explanations(e.g., mental illness) and toward understanding how social structures, norms, and the level of integration within a community influence behavior

Key point here!!

Durkheim's concept of anomie and the importance of collective consciousness highlight that broader social structures — *rather than purely personal factors* — can powerfully shape individual behaviors.

Group Discussion!!!!

Group Discussion

10:00

During the COVID-19 pandemic, lockdowns disrupted established social structures (e.g., remote work, virtual education, restricted social interaction). In your view, **did these abrupt shifts in societal norms create widespread feelings of anomie (normlessness or alienation)?**

If yes, what new or intensified forms of deviance emerged as a result of this destabilization?

If no, what societal mechanisms prevented anomie from taking hold?

Pick one and make an argument for your choice. Elect one speaker to present your point.

Strain Theories

A Hypothetical

Who achieved success in American Society?

- **Scenario A.** John, who has a PhD in physics, lives in a one-bedroom apartment because his postdoc position pays 25k a year, additionally has 150,000 in student debt
- **Scenario B.** Joe, who is a relatively successful drug dealer who lives in a four-bedroom home, drives a Hummer, dropped out of high school in 10th grade, and makes more than 90k a year.

Merton's Strain Theory

Robert K. Merton (1938)

Expanded on Durkheim's concept of anomie

A state of “normlessness” caused by rapid social change (e.g., industrialization), where societal rules collapse, leading to deviance

Merton's Concept of Strain

Anomie is the structural strain itself - the imbalance between society's emphasis on cultural goals (wealth, success) and the lack of access to legitimate institutionalized means (education, jobs) to achieve them, which leads to deviance

Merton's Strain Theory

Cultural Goals: Societal aspirations (e.g., wealth, success)

Institutionalized Means: Legitimate paths to achieve goals (e.g., education, hard work)

Strain: Disconnect between cultural goals and access to institutionalized means

Anomie: Normlessness due to societal pressure/breakdown which leads to deviance

Merton's Strain Theory

These **adaptations** reflect responses to the strain between society's emphasis on success (goals) and unequal access to legitimate opportunities (means)

Conformity: Accepts both societal goals and legitimate means (e.g., pursuing wealth through education/hard work)

Innovation: Accepts cultural goals but uses illegitimate means to achieve them (e.g., theft, fraud)

Ritualism: Abandons cultural goals but rigidly follows institutionalized means (e.g., bureaucratic workers “going through the motions”)

Retreatism: Rejects both goals and means, withdrawing from society (e.g., substance abuse, homelessness)

Rebellion: Rejects societal goals and means, replacing them with new ones (e.g., revolutionaries seeking to overthrow systems)

Five Adaptations to Strain

Mode	Accept Goals?	Accept Means?	Example
Conformity	Yes	Yes	Pursue career via education
Innovation	Yes	No	Drug trade for wealth
Ritualism	No	Yes	Bureaucrat follows rules rigidly
Retreatism	No	No	Substance abuse, dropout
Rebellion	<i>Replace</i>	<i>Replace</i>	Revolutionary movements

General Strain Theory

Robert Agnew (1992)

Key Shift from Merton:

Strain is not just structural (goals vs. means) but individual-level

Strain → Negative emotion (anger) → deviance

Three Types of Strain

1 Failure to Achieve Goals

Disjunction between expectations and reality

Example: Poor grades despite effort

2 Removal of Positive Stimuli

Loss of valued resources

Example: Loss of a loved one, breakup

3 Presence of Negative Stimuli

Exposure to harm

Example: Abuse, bullying, discrimination.

How Strain Leads to Deviance

Strain → Negative emotion (anger) → deviance

The link between negative emotion and deviance depends on coping mechanisms:

(1) **Legitimate Coping:** Therapy, exercise, social support

(2) **Illegitimate Coping:** Drug use, violence, theft

Lack of access to legitimate coping resources (e.g., financial stability, mentorship, mental health support) increases the likelihood of deviant behavior.

Comparing Merton and GST

Merton (1938)	GST (Agnew, 1992)
Structural goals	Individual-level strains
Inability to achieve goals legitimately	Negative relationships/experiences
5 modes of adaptation	Anger/frustration and coping mechanisms

Group Discussion!!!!

Group Discussion

10:00

With what we just learned about General Strain Theory, come up with an idea for a product (e.g., app, social media group, website, etc...) that would help individuals access legitimate coping resources (e.g., therapy, exercise, social support) during negative emotional events (like anger) before they escalate to deviance.

For example, a meditation app that alerts users during heart rate spikes from stress induced anxiety.

Have fun with it! Think outside the 

Elect one speaker to present your point.

Have a great weekend!

